



Surveys & Polling

Can We Trust People to Know Themselves?

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Asking the Right Questions

The questions we ask determine the answers we get.

Both polls and surveys depend on asking good questions in clear ways.

We *absolutely* need to know how the questions were worded before drawing conclusions from a poll.

Some Types of Polls

Push poll: an opinion poll with an ulterior motive to sway voters using manipulative questions.

Straw poll: a quick, unofficial poll just to gauge basic opinion on something.

Exit poll: poll of voters taken immediately after they've voted to see how they voted and predict results.

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3. Are the answer choices (e.g., categories) appropriate?
 - Exhaustive (cover all logical possibilities)
 - Mutually exclusive (can't simultaneously be X *and* NOT X)
4. Is the question clear and appropriate?

The Key to Good Survey Questions

“Good” survey/poll questions:

1. Are easily understood
2. Are administered consistently
3. Clarify the type of answer needed
4. Avoid over-burdening respondents
5. Rely on information that respondents have access to
6. Maximize respondent willingness to answer

How do you know when you questions are good enough?

- Ask for feedback! (focus groups, peer review, pre-testing)
- Examine the data!
- Check predicted relationships for weirdness.
- Embed experiments (ask again differently, “attention checks”).
- Measure the consistency of respondents over time.